

dicates that an equal number have sex with affinal relations or rather, those who fall in the category of potential marital partners), the most obvious issues are those of sexuality, force and consent. Of those who had sex with blood relatives, more than half were sexual encounters between siblings (53 per cent). Thirty-six per cent declared that it "wasn't consensual sex" and that they were "forced into it". Rather tellingly, nearly one in ten males (9 per cent) and rather more women (15 per cent) said that their first sexual encounter was without their consent. So, for instance, of the cities featuring the highest responses of force for this question, in Ahmedabad 29 per cent of the 187 female respondents reported force, 28 per cent of the 179 Bangalore respondents, 25 per cent of the 154 responding in Patna and 20 per cent of the 182 respondents from Chennai.

Three per cent of people say they had their first sexual experience by

mation about Indian women having sex with eunuchs more credible than I would have otherwise done. In terms of non-heteronormative sexual practices, we must remember that consensual homosexuality is still unlawful in India, a situation that criminalises and socially stigmatises people on the basis of personal actions and sexual choices. Three per cent of respondents declared that they desired only same-sex relationships and were out of the closet, 4 per cent that they desired same-sex relations but were not out, 81 per cent returned responses that they were firmly heterosexual, and 6 per cent responded that they were bisexual. Finally, 6 per cent of women and 16 per cent of men have had homosexual experiences (an average of 11 per cent). We must, however, be conscious of the terminologies we use to discuss these sexual practices as the literature on same-sex relations in India strongly indicates that they do not necessarily

SEX UNDER DURESS EXISTS AND IS NOW BEING SPOKEN OF. NINE PER CENT MEN AND 15 PER CENT WOMEN SAID THEIR FIRST SEXUAL ENCOUNTER WAS WITHOUT THEIR CONSENT.

paying for it. Interestingly, the gender breakdown of this was 4 per cent men and 1 per cent women. Furthermore, 19 per cent of male respondents and 2 per cent of female respondents claim that they have had sex with prostitutes from the opposite sex. When asked in a different question specifically whether respondents had had sex with hijras or eunuchs, 19 per cent of men and 17 per cent of women respond in the affirmative, an improbably high number. I am genuinely surprised at the high incidence of sex with eunuchs amongst female respondents, though the highest positive responses for both men and women come from a cluster of just three cities: Kolkata, Chennai and Ahmedabad. Having recently read a news item on the BBC.com about a small but noteworthy number of gigolos working in Calcutta servicing female clients with wealth and resources, I find the infor-

converge into a western style "gay" or even "homosexual" identity so we should be wary of glibly attaching labels to a range of complex sexual practices and social arrangements that accommodate them. Whilst the sexy secrets of this affluent generation might appear interesting and titillating, and reveal the extent to which sex is being bought and pornographic images sold, we must ask ourselves more serious questions of how we might respond as a public to the high rates of sexual force and abuse particularly of minors, and to the continuing illegality of homosexuality in a country in which same-sex relations are clearly widespread.

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